

Independent Tribune
LIFESTYLES

Section

B

SUNDAY, MAY 28, 2000



... *specializing in*

Raptor Rehab

By **BETH SNEAD**
Features Editor

HUNTERSVILLE — They're not the seed-pecking songbirds that eat at your backyard bird feeder. But it's becoming more and more common to see them at home in town.

The habitat for birds of prey, or raptors,

The woman worked for a developer at a new neighborhood site in the Mallard Creek area.

A cedar tree on the property had been partially downed by a lightning strike several days earlier, and when workers came to take the tree the rest of the way down, they found the baby.

Before the baby-hatching season is over, the center will likely have taken in two dozen or more baby owls. These barred owls above are among 16 babies being raised by a resident pair of adult owls.



is sharing daily. The hunters themselves are being preyed on by growth and development. As the city limits are spreading out into their woodlands, great horned owls, barred owls, and hawks are becoming regular townies.

The issue of owls in the city was raised



A pair of baby barred owls turn their wary gaze to the camera

a few weeks back when a Concord man became convinced that he saw a great horned owl snatch a neighbor's Chihuahua.

Those fears were allayed by experts at the Carolina Raptor Center who explained that an owl can't fly off with an animal that outweighs it. The largest of the great horned owls will likely never weigh more than four pounds. The missing dog weighed 10 pounds, and eventually made its way back home.

After the hubbub died down, the Raptor Center folks invited the Independent Tribune to visit the Huntersville complex to see their conservation and education efforts first-hand.

During that visit, the problem with raptors losing their habitat was evidenced by an office worker who brought a baby barred owl in for rescue.

She said one of the workers brought it to her, and told her it was a baby barred owl. He'd seen one before, he said. It's not known how he gained his knowledge of juvenile owls. He may have been a nature enthusiast, or he may have made owls homeless before.

Staff and volunteers examined the owl, and found that it hadn't been hurt in the incident. It was cleared to go back to a neighboring tree on the property so that it could be reunited with its mother.

Betty O'Leary, director of bird care, asked the woman if there were another tree near the downed one.

No. The nearest tree was about a quarter mile away, the woman said. All the other trees had been cleared for development.

That was too far to risk it, O'Leary said. The baby will be adopted by owl parents at the raptor center until it is big enough to be trained to take care of itself, then will be released at another location.

They see it all the time, said Alan Barnhardt, executive director of the center.

Not all of the cases are as directly traceable to a bird being pushed out of its habitat, but many of their problems would be less severe if they didn't have to live in such close quarters with humankind.

Being hit by cars, and being orphaned like the Mallard Creek baby owl are the leading reasons raptors have to come in for rehabilitation, said Linda Engelmann, a 14-year Raptor Center volunteer who has logged more than 5,000 hours since she began helping out. Her husband, Matthias Engelmann, is the rehabilitation coordinator.

Barnhardt doesn't wax emotional about the need to protect owls and other birds of prey. It's not that they're majestic, beautiful birds that enrich the natural order. It's not because we'd miss them if they were gone — though all of that is true.

It's because we need them to keep us apprised of our environment, he said.

"The raptors have become indicators of our environmental health," said Barnhardt.

He talks about the heavy use of the insecticide DDT in the 1960s.

People were using it for everything from dusting it on bed sheets to kill fleas to spraying it in neighborhoods to keep mos-



Staff photos by Stacy Finch

Hannah is a rescued kestrel from Concord. Raptor Center workers believe someone took her in and tried to hand-raise her as a baby. She was "imprinted" to think she was a human, then was either released or escaped. She was looking for a husband on Knollcrest Drive in Concord when she began following a man who was relaxing in his backyard. The man put his arm out and she lighted on it. He turned her over to the center.

quitoes down.

The raptors were eating lots of it in the form of poisoned fish, mice and rats. After ingesting high concentrates of DDT the birds' eggshells started to get thin — so thin the eggs were crushed in the nest by the weight of their mothers.

Only after the population of birds of prey started dying off did people realize the harmful effects of the chemical, which was later outlawed in the United States.

The birds are good environmental watchdogs because they're at the top of their food chain, with no natural enemies except people.

But they've found some friends

among the people at the Raptor Center.

The center takes in more than 500 birds of prey each year from North and South Carolina including American and bald eagles, vultures, hawks, falcons, and kestrels and more. The center has become known for its rehabilitation techniques, and regularly takes in birds from across the U.S. when other centers are not able to help them.

The center also gives hundreds of educational programs each year.

To learn more about raptors, call the center at 875-6521, or visit Tuesday through Saturday from 10 a.m. to 5 p.m., and Sunday 1 to 5 p.m. The one-mile nature trail offers a look at more than 20 different species of raptors.

The center is located in the Latta Plantation Preserve. To get there from Cabarrus County, take Poplar Tent Road to Huntersville-Concord Road, turn left and continue all the way through Huntersville. The name of the road will change to Gilead as you go through town. Cross Interstate 77, then begin looking for McCoy Road to the left. Turn left on McCoy Road about 2 miles, turn right on Hambricht, then 2 miles more, turn left onto Beatties Ford Road. You'll see a stone wall on either side of the road, then turn right onto Sample Road, following signs to Latta Plantation Park. Once you're in the park, the center is a 1/2 mile or left.

owl in for rescue.

spraying it in neighborhoods to keep mos-

But they've found some friends than 20 different species of raptors. left.



Raptor Center workers treat a hawk with a damaged wing at left and above. At right, they examine a homeless baby barred owl.

